

Chapter 3 – Adult Attachment Prototypes and Their Clinical Manifestations

I. Securely Attached Adults

- Secure attachment in the infant-caregiver bond develops largely as a function of *consistent maternal responsiveness* and *contingent matching*.
- Securely attached adults report more positive and stronger bonds with their parents. Many but not all secure adults report having had less childhood adversity than insecure individuals.
- Secure children in the Strange Situation and secure adults on the AAI find a healthy balance between attachment and autonomous exploration.

State of Mind on the AAI

- Clear valuing of attachment, ease with the topic of attachment, the capacity to talk about attachment themes and experiences with highly coherent discourse, metacognitive monitoring, and fresh speech.
- Show a strong personal identity and are able to see and articulate how early attachment experiences had an effect on their personality development. They are comfortable with their own limitations and imperfections and can talk about failures of their own parents with a sense of proportion and context, and sometimes with forgiveness and compassion.

Self-Report Studies of Adult Romantic Relationships

- A person with a secure attachment style is comfortable with closeness, able to depend on others, and is not worried about being abandoned or unloved.
- Likely to seek emotional support from their partners when distressed as well as to provide support to a distressed partner.
- When problems arise in relationships, they show an enhanced capacity for self-reflection and greater problem-solving ability; secure-adult relationships tend to be more stable and satisfying than those of insecure adults and are characterized by greater longevity, trust, commitment, and interdependence.

Attachment-Related Memories and Emotions

- Are readily able to access trust-related memories. Greater access to both positive and negative memories than insecure adults.

Self-Representation

- Secure adults are more ego-resilient and less anxious than insecure individuals and they describe themselves mostly in positive terms but also are able to acknowledge negative self attributes. Overall a positive and coherent sense of self.

In Psychotherapy

- Secure in contrast to insecure adults are much more likely to report positive working alliances and to perceive their therapists as emotionally responsive and accepting. Are predisposed to experience the therapist as a secure base and have greater depth of exploration in treatment.

II. Dismissing Insecure Adults

- Avoidant attachment in children and dismissing attachment in adults is largely the outcome of *consistent and repetitive rejection of the child's attachment behaviors* by the primary attachment figure. Such reject results in deactivation of the attachment system.

- The child's natural instinctual tendency to seek proximity and protection when distressed is met with punishment, distancing, or neglect. The child learns to suppress attachment behavior in order to receive adequate or minimal care.

- Less actively rejecting behaviors by the parents that contribute to avoidant patterns in infancy include terminating their infants cries less often and holding them less during the first months of life.

 - The infant is left in a "painful" state for considerable periods of time.

 - The context is then ripe for the infant eventually to develop alternative links in its behavioral chains, in which some behavior on the part of the infant terminates its distress (e.g., turning its focus in a rather forced manner of exploration).

- Dismissing adults function with a deactivated attachment system and rely on non-attachment-related systems for coping and adaptation.

 - They often manifest exaggerated exploratory behavior with a manner of "I don't need any help" pseudoindependence. As a consequence, adults with dismissing attachment are unlikely to seek social support and are highly likely to engage in distancing coping behaviors.

 - Dismissing attachment is an organization of thought that permits attachment to remain relatively deactivated.

State of Mind on the AAI

- High degree of unrealistic idealization with respect to one or both parents. Emphasizing parental activities over quality of the early relationship. Giving a positive endorsement to negative parental behaviors.

- A clear tendency to minimize negative experiences. A strong tendency to dismiss or derogate attachment. An inability to access attachment-related memories.

- Remoteness from emotions when answering questions that typically evoke attachment-related emotions. Rare mention of hurt, distress, or vulnerability. Emphasis on the self as strong, independent, or normal.

Self-Report Studies of Adult Romantic Relationships

- In relationships, dismissing adults engage primarily in deactivating attachment strategies.
- Tend to be vigilant about becoming needy, intimate, dependent, or emotional; they tend to deny vulnerability, emphasize their personal strengths, avoid threats, and resist becoming dependent on anyone. Characterized by fear of intimacy, emotional highs and lows, and jealousy. Uncomfortable with closeness and intimacy, not confident in others' availability, and not particularly worried about being abandoned.
- Even though they tend to characterize relational experiences more negatively, they typically report less relational distress than secure individuals.
- Frequent negative moods are related to emotional cutoff (e.g. suppression).

Attachment-Related Memories and Emotions

- As a consequence of deactivating the attachment system, adults with dismissing attachment report fewer emotional memories than secure adults, and they have poor immediate recall of information regarding attachment-related experiences.
- Avoidant individuals appear to be particularly good at turning their attention away from troubling attachment-related thoughts and at the same time defusing the autonomic arousal associated with such thoughts.

Self Representation

- Dismissing adults tend to inflate their self-esteem defensively in the face of attachment threats, and tend to project unwanted self traits onto others.
- Avoidant persons tend to under-evaluate the perception of self–other similarity. To perceive themselves as dissimilar from others may result from projection onto others of traits that they do not want to possess. The avoidant person's perceptions of others are constructed around defensive projection.
- Despite their tendency to present a normal, positive self-image, dismissing adults generally have a more negative self-image than secure adults.

In Psychotherapy

- They are unlikely to seek therapy voluntarily unless an acute emotional crisis forces the issue of treatment. In therapy, they are far less self-disclosing than secure or anxious patients.

Profile Summary

- “Denial of attachment needs,” “compulsive self-reliance,” and “dismissal of threats and of the need for attachment figure availability.” “Deactivating strategies involve inhibition of the primary attachment strategy, proximity seeking.”
- Dismissing individuals have two main goals in relationships: 1) Gaining whatever they need while maintaining distance, control, and self-reliance, and 2) Ignoring or denying needs and avoiding negative emotional states that might trigger attachment-system activation.

III. Anxious-Preoccupied Insecure Adults

- Ambivalent/resistant attachment in children and anxious-preoccupied attachment in adults is the outcome of a prolonged pattern of *inconsistency of responsiveness from the attachment figure* and of *over-involving the child in the caregiver's state of mind*. Such experience produces hyperactivation of the infant's attachment system.
- Caregivers tend to be inconsistently responsive to their infant's needs, being sometimes unavailable and at other times intrusive, overprotective and interfering with their children's engagement in exploration. Anxious attachment is "rooted in parental anxiety and inconsistency."
- In relationships, they predominately use hyperactivating strategies:
 - They include a strong approach orientation toward relationship partners, attempts to elicit their involvement, care, and support through clinging and controlling responses, and cognitive and behavioral efforts aimed at minimizing distance from them and establishing not only physical contact but also perceived self-other similarity, intimacy, and "oneness".

State of Mind on the AAI

- An excessive, confused, and unobjective preoccupation with particular attachment relationships or experiences. Some individuals seem fearfully preoccupied with and overwhelmed by traumatic experiences.
- Anxious-preoccupied adults often show numerous entangled and disappointing relationships wherein they tend to fixate on themes of rejection and abandonment by others. In such relationships they show an excessive need for reassurance and a limited capacity for self-soothing.

Self-Report Studies of Adult Romantic Relationships

- Experienced love as involving obsession, desire for reciprocation and union, emotional highs and lows, and extreme sexual attraction and jealousy.
- Described as having overdependence on relationship partners and a tendency to detect threats in nearly every transaction.
 - They intensify negative emotional responses to threatening events and heighten mental rumination on threat-related concerns, keeping them active in working memory,
 - They foster anxious, hypervigilant attention to relationship partners and rapid detection of possible signs of disapproval, waning interest, or impending abandonment.
 - An anxious person is comfortable with closeness and is fairly confident in the availability of others, but is very worried about being abandoned and unloved.

Attachment-Related Memories and Emotions

- Anxious-preoccupied adults remain preoccupied with past hurts. They tend to ruminate about the past and engage primarily in emotion-focused coping.

- Were more likely to report increased needs for reassurances from others, and, in turn, this increased their vulnerability to depressive symptoms. Both maladaptive perfectionism and ineffective coping mediated depression in both anxious and avoidant individuals.

Self Representation

- Anxious-preoccupied adults score low on measures of self-confidence and have a weak or poorly developed sense of self.
- They have a less differentiated self-structure and show poor self–other differentiation . . . and tend to over-evaluate the perception of self–other similarity.

In Psychotherapy

- Preoccupied adults show a tendency to merge with the therapist to “reduce the fear of being unloved.”
- Have a weaker working alliance than do secure patients. Their tendency to have an intense level of anxiety in psychotherapy can interfere with progress over the course of treatment. Preoccupied anxiety tends to impede progress not in the beginning but later in therapy.

Profile Summary

- The main goal of hyper-activating strategies is to get an attachment figure, perceived as unreliable or insufficiently responsive, to pay more attention and provide protection or support.
- These strategies can easily encourage intrusive, coercive, and aggressive behaviors toward a relationship partner that promote relationship dysfunction, partner dissatisfaction, and eventual rejection or abandonment—ironically and tragically, the very outcomes most dreaded by attachment-anxious people.

IV. Disorganized/Fearful Insecure Adults

- Disorganized attachment in children and disorganized or fearful attachment in adults is the outcome of frightening and frightened parental behavior and unresolved trauma or loss in a parent, which leads to the parent being present but not present to the child and thereby repetitively unresponsive.
- Adults with disorganized/fearful attachment are more likely to report that one or more parent had a drinking problem and/or to report physical or sexual abuse.
- They manifest contradictory deactivating and hyperactivating attachment styles, in different circumstances at different times, or sometimes simultaneously. Such individuals show a strong propensity to dissociate in the face of attachment-related threats.

Self-Report Studies of Adult Romantic Relationships

- Engage in both deactivating and hyperactivating attachment strategies in relationships.

- Rated significantly lower than the secure and preoccupied group on self-disclosure, intimacy, level of romantic involvement, reliance on others, and use of others as a secure base when upset.
- Fearful adults tend to become passive, unassertive, or socially inhibited in relationships. Manifest persistent themes of interpersonal distrust, vulnerability, and passive withdrawal and their efforts to recall and recount these painful experiences may exhibit fragmented and dissociative qualities. They show combined impairments in affective self-regulation and social competencies.
- As a consequence, disorganized/fearful adults tend to have less satisfying relationships than other insecure or secure adults. In close relationships, they show a confusing vacillation among detached, dependent, and controlling postures. They also tend to report a greater level of interpersonal conflict than other insecure or secure adults.

Attachment-Related Memories and Emotions

- Show both a preoccupation with past hurts and an inaccessibility of past memories and emotions of early attachment relationships.
- Show high levels of dissociative behaviors and symptoms and, associated with this, diminished emotional expressiveness. Compared to other insecure or secure adults, they score lower on measures of self-disclosure, intimacy, reliance on others, and the use of others as a secure base.

Self Representation

- The self is poorly developed and often fragmented, and dissociated self-states are common in this group. Disorganized/fearful adults have chronic low self-esteem.

In Psychotherapy

- Present a confusing combination of dismissing and preoccupied attachment behaviors, with dismissing behaviors predominating earlier and preoccupied predominating later in treatment.
- Fearful-avoidant attachment involves an intense distrust of others, behavioral avoidance of relationships and a view of self as unlovable and unworthy of care. Individuals reporting high levels of fearful attachment showed significantly less improvement following 16 sessions of psychotherapy.

Profile Summary

- They have trouble choosing decisively between deactivating and hyperactivating strategies. They enact both strategies in a haphazard, confused, and chaotic manner.
- Because of these individuals' failure to achieve any of the goals of the major attachment strategies: safety and security following proximity seeking . . . there is a defensive deactivation of the attachment system or an intense and chronic activation of the attachment system until security-enhancing proximity is attained.
- These individuals are relatively inhibited and unassertive, and their lives may have been scarred by physical or sexual abuse or other attachment-related traumas. "Fearful avoidants" are the least secure, least trusting, and most troubled of adolescents and adults. Have especially negative representations of their romantic partners. They are cognitively closed and rigid.